

Five Checks *That Lie*

Five green checkmarks. None of them proved what I thought they proved. I found all five in my own work, in one week -- not in someone else's.

RUN THESE AGAINST YOUR OWN STATUS CHECKS

In order. Each takes a few minutes and tells you honestly whether a green light means what you think it means.

01 The bill only I could see

- LOOKS LIKE** A check kept passing every time. It was quietly paying a real vendor for a real call, every single run.
- VERIFY** Cut that connection off and run the check again. If it still passes, it was never checking your work.
- REAL PASS** The check runs on a stand-in, not the live paid service. A separate, clearly labeled check covers the real thing.

02 The link that goes nowhere

- LOOKS LIKE** A report said "done" and handed back a link. The link opened to an empty page.
- VERIFY** Open the actual link. Don't trust that a link exists -- check where it leads.
- REAL PASS** The check confirms what's on the other side of the link, not just that a link got produced.

03 The demo only the demo team could run

- LOOKS LIKE** Everything passed internally. The moment it ran outside that setup, it broke immediately.
- VERIFY** Hand it to someone outside the process. Watch them run it cold, in their own setup.
- REAL PASS** The check runs the way a real person would actually encounter it -- not inside a setup built just to make it pass.

04 The check that cannot fail

- LOOKS LIKE** A quality check meant for scanned paperwork, tested with a clean typed version instead of a real scan.
- VERIFY** Ask one plain question: what would actually make this fail? If you can't answer, it isn't checking anything.
- REAL PASS** The check runs on the real, messy input the process was built for -- not a clean stand-in.

05 The fix that only fixed one copy

- LOOKS LIKE** A number got corrected in one place and everyone signed off. A second copy, the one customers actually saw, still had the old number.
- VERIFY** Check where a customer or reader would actually see the result -- not just where it lives in the system.
- REAL PASS** The number is correct everywhere it shows up, not just in the one place someone happened to check.

"If a check has never failed, you have not verified that it works."

Want the mechanics behind any of these? Ask Claude or ChatGPT to walk you through it -- that part takes minutes, not days.

NEXT STEP

If one of these sounds familiar, I've probably already found it in someone else's pipeline too. **Book a free 20-minute brief** and we'll work out what's actually true before you trust the next green light.

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